

Waders, gulls, and auks

Order Charadriiformes

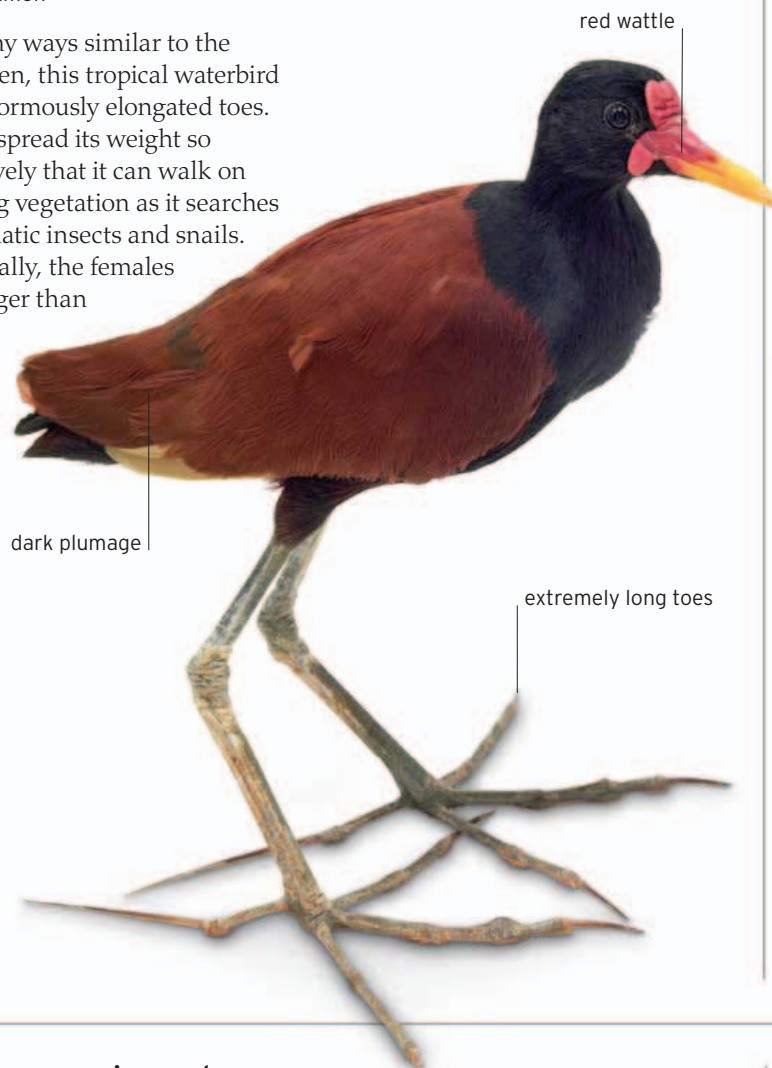
Wattled jacana

Jacana jacana

- ↔ 7–10 in (18–25 cm)
- 📍 S. Central America, South America
- ⊗ Common

In many ways similar to the moorhen, this tropical waterbird has enormously elongated toes. These spread its weight so effectively that it can walk on floating vegetation as it searches for aquatic insects and snails. Unusually, the females are larger than

the males, defend territories, and compete with rivals for mates; each may mate with up to three males, which incubate the eggs and care for the young.



Black-winged stilt

Himantopus himantopus

- ↔ 14–16 in (36–41 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, Africa, North, Central, and South America
- ⊗ Common

The long, pink legs of this black and white wader allow it to feed in much deeper water than most of its competitors. It gathers small aquatic animals by sweeping its slender, straight black bill through the water, detecting them by touch—although it also seizes insects from the surface. The black-winged stilt may also forage on land, but has to bend its legs awkwardly to pick prey off the ground.



Eurasian oystercatcher

Haematopus ostralegus

- ↔ 16–19 in (40–48 cm)
- 📍 Europe, NW., N., and E. Africa, SW., C., E., and S. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Recognizable by its piping calls, this bird has a long bill adapted for feeding on shelled mollusks, such as limpets, with a sharp tip, which it uses to detach them from rocks or pry them apart to sever the shell-closing muscle within. But some oystercatchers probe for prey in sand and mud, and their bills are more pointed.



Common ringed plover

Charadrius hiaticula

- ↔ 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
- 📍 N. North America, Greenland, Europe, Asia, Africa, Madagascar
- ⊗ Common

When this compact, short-necked plover is feeding on a mudflat, the contrasting white collar and black bands on its head and breast can be conspicuous. But on a shingle beach, where it nests, the pattern disrupts its outline so effectively that the bird is almost invisible. Nesting pairs rely on this for protection, but when their young hatch, the adults may lure predators away from them with a “broken wing” display that makes them look like temptingly easy prey.



Eurasian curlew

Numenius arquata

- ↔ 20–24 in (51–61 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, Africa
- ⊗ Near threatened

This large, brown-streaked wader has a long, downcurved bill—the perfect tool for probing coastal sand or mud for burrowing prey such as worms, clams, and tiny crabs. The curlew also feeds on the surface, especially in summer, when breeding adults move to inland nesting sites and feed on insects, earthworms, and berries. This bird has a loud ringing “courli” call.

Australian pratincole

Stiltia isabella

- ↔ 9 in (23 cm)
- 📍 Australia, Indonesia, Malaysia, Papua New Guinea
- ⊗ Common

This sandy-brown bird has very long, pointed black wings, a white underside, and a vent with a chestnut-and-black patch at the side. When breeding, the bill is bright red at the base. Non-breeding birds are duller, with a mostly black bill, black spotting on the throat, and smaller flank markings. Pratincoles feed on invertebrates.